



PHOTO INDOMANIA: Prime Minister Abe; the 2007 Festival of India in Japan

Japanese naval official, who does not rule out the possibility of Japan guarding sea lanes for India in the future. "We enjoy inter-operability with the Indian Navy now. We can secure sea lanes when India routes its oil from Omsk in Russia," adds the official.

However, all is not so smooth on the economic front. While India wants investment in infrastructure, Japan is insisting on tax breaks and special economic zones around the freight and industrial corridors—something India is not too keen on. Japan is also keen on early completion of the economic partnership agreement that the two sides

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■ Japan is expected to offer India energy-efficient technology. Abe's talks will focus on clean energy and other environmental issues.

■ In view of difficulties in extending civilian nuclear cooperation to India, Japan wants greater clarity on the Indo-US nuclear deal.

■ Abe is keen on increasing the volume of bilateral trade. The two countries will announce a roadmap for future cooperation.

■ The first meeting of the Indo-Japanese CEOs forum is to be held during Abe's visit to India.

■ Japanese university vice-chancellors will hold talks with their Indian counterparts.

Japanese defence official. The defence exchange between India and Japan has been a success, with back-to-back visits to Japan by all three Indian service chiefs early this year, and a defence policy dialogue held in April, where India agreed to provide training to Japanese self-defence forces. Abe is also expected to intensify security cooperation with India.

Japanese defence forces see India's role as a major force multiplier for their efforts in curbing piracy and securing sea lanes. "India is located strategically at the centre of a sea lane that connects Asia-Pacific to Europe, the Middle East and Africa. Every day, 75 oil tankers pass through the Indian Ocean. We need India's help," says a senior

are negotiating. Indo-Japanese bilateral trade amounts to just \$7 billion (Rs 28,000 crore), compared to Sino-Indian trade, which stands at \$25 billion (Rs 1 lakh crore). Abe is keen on correcting this. The first meeting of the Indo-Japanese CEOs forum will be held during his visit. Over a hundred CEOs from Japan's top companies will be part of the business delegation. "We hope that we can have an early finalisation of the economic partnership agreement, which will help decrease taxes and push bilateral trade," says Masakazu Kubota, managing director of the Japan Business Federation.

The bigger gulf is on the nuclear issue. DPJ, known for its tough stand on the issue, may create problems for the

Indo-US nuclear deal in the Nuclear Suppliers' Group, of which Japan is a member. The Foreign Office is cautious. "We acknowledge that India is a responsible nuclear power, but we want to see how the separation plan is implemented and what the nature of the safeguards agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency is," says Shimizu.

Despite the differences, there is little doubt that the bilateral relationship is developing impressively. "Japan is rediscovering India. Prime Minister Abe understands the importance of India for Japan's future," says Vibhav Upadhyaya, who heads India Centre, a non-profit organisation working to cement Indo-Japanese ties. Last year, the foundation set a record of sorts when over two lakh Japanese turned up at the Yoyogi Park in Tokyo to celebrate the best of India, listening to sitar maestro Nishat Khan's recital and watching Japanese dancer Masato Ono's Odissi performance. The next event, being planned for September, promises to be even bigger.

Stores in Japan now sell DVDs not only of "The Dancing Maharaja", as the southern star Rajinikanth is known, but also of new Bollywood movies with Japanese subtitles. Thousands of Japanese youngsters now throng the 300 Indian restaurants in Tokyo, most of which have DJs belting out the latest Bollywood chartbusters. At the food chain Nakamura Ya, the top grossing item is the Indian curry. However, India still does not have a cultural centre in Tokyo.

It is clear that strategic vision now guides Japan's relationship with India. With the US preoccupied with West Asia, Japan is looking at India to play a pivotal role in Asia. India needs to make the most of the opportunity with proactive diplomacy. For starters, it should elevate Japan from a retiree diplomatic post to a priority outpost, and engage with it across the political spectrum—an opportunity Manmohan Singh missed when he failed to interact with the Japanese Opposition during his visit to the country in December 2006. The two Asian giants have to ensure that the bilateral relationship moves beyond declarations of global partnership. Abe's visit will hopefully be a step in this direction. ■